

good system must be that of developing first-class men; and under systematic management the best man rises to the top more certainly and more rapidly than ever before.³

Unfortunately, Taylor's insistence that scientific management does not stand in opposition to finding and promoting the best individuals was quickly forgotten. In fact, the productivity gains to be had through the early scientific management tactics, such as time and motion study, task-plus-bonus, and especially functional foremanship (the forerunner of today's functional departments), were so significant that subsequent generations of managers lost sight of the importance of the people who were implementing them.

This has led to two problems: (1) business systems became overly rigid and thereby failed to take advantage of the adaptability, creativity, and wisdom of individual workers, and (2) there has been an overemphasis on planning, prevention, and procedure, which enable organizations to achieve consistent results in a mostly static world. On the factory floor, these problems have been tackled head on by the lean manufacturing movement, and those lessons have spread throughout many modern corporations. And yet in new product development, entrepreneurship, and innovation work in general we are still using an outdated framework.

My hope is that the Lean Startup movement will not fall into the same reductionist trap. We are just beginning to uncover the rules that govern entrepreneurship, a method that can improve the odds of startup success, and a systematic approach to building new and innovative products. This in no way diminishes the traditional entrepreneurial virtues: the primacy of vision, the willingness to take bold risks, and the courage required in the face of overwhelming odds. Our society needs the creativity and vision of entrepreneurs more than ever. In fact, it is precisely because these are such precious resources that we cannot afford to waste them.